AI PRACTICE CONVERSATION REHEARSAL

Compensation Conversation Rehearsal

A 20-minute branching rehearsal for clarifying package terms, making a reasoned ask, handling location-based pushback, exploring real levers, and closing safely in writing.

Use exact units, role-relevant evidence, calm questions, honest boundaries, and a written record - never bluff, guess, or negotiate against an undefined package.

VERSION 1.0

FORMAT BRANCHING CONVERSATION REHEARSAL

STATUS LEARNER READY

AI-PRACTICE / COMPENSATION-CONVERSATION-REHEARSAL

PREPARE A CONVERSATION, NOT A DEMAND

Negotiate with clear units, relevant evidence, and calm boundaries

This rehearsal teaches how to clarify the offer, state a reasoned target, handle location-based pushback, explore legitimate package levers, and close in writing without bluffing or inventing market facts.

TEACHING AND ADVICE BOUNDARY

All people, companies, amounts, dates, bands, offers, and dialogue are fictional teaching data - not compensation benchmarks, legal advice, or tax advice. Verify your own terms and seek qualified advice where needed.

01	02	03	04	05
Clarify	**Align**	**Anchor**	**Explore**	**Confirm**
Confirm model, currency, period, gross/net basis, components, conditions, and deadline.	Restate interest and the role scope or decision the conversation should resolve.	State one reasoned target in comparable units, then pause.	Ask which levers and constraints are real; trade only across acceptable terms.	Summarize agreed facts, open items, owners, and timing in writing.

The 20-minute rehearsal

Clock	Scenario	Observable skill
0-3	Prepare the offer facts, target, rationale, fallback, questions, and deadline.	Every amount has a currency, time unit, component, and certainty label.
3-7	Recruiter asks for expectations before sharing the full package.	Clarify role/level/model and respond without anchoring against an unknown unit.
7-11	Recruiter cites a location-based band.	Acknowledge, clarify the constraint, re-anchor in role scope and evidence, then pause.
11-15	Base cannot move.	Explore only real package levers and compare their value/risk explicitly.
15-18	Replay the weakest turn with one correction.	Improved response preserves truthful rationale and removes defensiveness or bluff.
18-20	Close and save the written summary.	Agreed facts, open questions, owner, next date, and no accidental acceptance.

OPERATING RULE

Ask one clarifying question, make one evidence-backed request, and then leave space for the other person to respond. More words do not create more leverage.

NORMALIZE THE LANGUAGE BEFORE NEGOTIATING

A number without its unit is not an offer

Separate fixed cash, variable pay, equity, benefits, one-time amounts, and working conditions. Do not compare monthly contractor revenue with annual employee salary or treat a conditional bonus as guaranteed cash.

Field	Clarify	Do not assume
Engagement model	Employee, employer-of-record, contractor, or another arrangement; employer/counterparty and governing terms.	That labels alone determine taxes, protections, or take-home value.
Fixed cash	Currency, annual/monthly/hourly unit, gross/net basis, pay schedule, review timing.	That conversion to another currency is fixed or fee-free.
Variable	Target, formula, individual/company conditions, cap, timing, historical payout if authorized.	That target bonus is guaranteed or paid pro rata.
Equity	Instrument, quantity, vesting, cliff, strike/exercise terms, liquidity, expiration, and documents.	A headline value equals realizable cash.
Benefits	Leave, insurance, retirement, equipment, learning, travel, notice, severance, and local availability.	The same benefit exists in every location or engagement model.
Working reality	Timezone overlap, on-call, travel, hours, equipment, expense policy, manager/team, and scope.	Remote means schedule autonomy or no travel.
Decision timing	Written-offer date, questions deadline, acceptance deadline, start date, and contingencies.	A verbal discussion is the final written term.

FICTIONAL WORKED EXAMPLE - ADAPT THE METHOD, NOT THE FACTS

Item	Fictional fact	Conversation-safe interpretation
Fixed cash	USD 72,000 annual gross through an EOR.	Comparable only after confirming pay schedule, fees, local deductions, and written terms.
Bonus	Up to 10%, company and individual conditions not yet documented.	Treat as uncertain variable compensation until formula and payout rules are supplied.
Equity	Options mentioned verbally; no grant size or terms.	Record as unknown, not as current package value.
Work pattern	Four hours of IST-US overlap plus one on-call week in six.	A material time and recovery commitment to compare, clarify, and possibly negotiate.
Decision	Written offer expected Friday; response requested Monday.	Ask for complete documents and a reasonable review window before treating the deadline as fixed.

COMPANION USE

Use the existing compensation and offer decision workbook for detailed normalization and risk comparison. This guide focuses on how to conduct the spoken conversation and confirm it safely afterward.

BUILD ONE DEFENSIBLE ANCHOR

Target, rationale, fallback, and boundary must agree

An anchor is a clear request in comparable units supported by role scope, level, and truthful evidence. It is not a copied benchmark, a bluff, or a claim about personal need.

Anchor card	What to prepare	Quality check
Ask	Specific component and number/range with currency, period, and gross/net basis.	The other person can repeat the request without guessing units.
Rationale	Role scope, level, responsibilities, scarce relevant capability, and verified interview/work evidence.	The reason explains value for this role, not rent, family costs, or an invented market statistic.
Package context	Which terms are confirmed, conditional, unknown, or material to your decision.	Fixed, variable, equity, benefits, and conditions are not collapsed into one number.
Fallback ladder	Acceptable alternatives ordered before the call.	Each fallback has real value to you and is available for discussion; no fake concessions.
Boundary	Term that makes the offer unacceptable or requires more diligence.	A private decision rule, stated professionally only when useful.
Evidence source	Written offer, recruiter clarification, current target-role evidence, and dated source notes.	Every factual claim is verifiable and no confidential employer data is exposed.

Sentence framework

I am excited about the role, especially [specific scope]. Based on the responsibilities we discussed and my evidence in [relevant capability], I would like to explore [component and precise unit]. How much flexibility is available within the approved package?

RATIONALE

Evidence, not autobiography

Use decisions and outcomes relevant to the role. Avoid long personal explanations, current living costs, or confidential details that do not help the company evaluate the request.

DELIVERY

Pause after the ask

Do not immediately discount your request or fill silence with extra concessions. Listen for the actual constraint, then choose the next question.

ETHICS BOUNDARY

Never invent a competing offer, current salary, benchmark, deadline, title, scope, or willingness to walk away. A negotiation that depends on a false fact is not a safe rehearsal outcome.

RESPOND TO LOCATION-BASED PUSHBACK CALMLY

Clarify the policy before arguing with it

Location may affect approved bands, engagement model, benefits, taxes, currency, or internal equity. The learner's job is to understand the real constraint, reconnect the request to role scope, explore legitimate alternatives, and preserve the relationship.

01	02	03	04	05
Acknowledge	**Clarify**	**Re-anchor**	**Explore**	**Pause**
Reflect the stated constraint without agreeing that every conclusion follows.	Ask whether the limit applies to base, total package, level, model, or location policy.	Return to the role's scope and the learner's verified relevant evidence.	Ask about approved alternatives, review timing, or level/scope alignment.	Let the recruiter respond; do not debate geography or repeat the ask emotionally.

FICTIONAL WORKED EXAMPLE - ADAPT THE METHOD, NOT THE FACTS

Speaker	Fictional conversation	Why the move works
Recruiter	For candidates based in India, this is already near the top of our band.	States a policy constraint but does not yet define component, level, or total-package boundary.
Candidate	Thank you for explaining that. Is the limit specific to fixed cash for this location, or does it also constrain level and the total package?	Acknowledges and asks one precise question before countering.
Recruiter	The fixed-cash band is location-based; level is confirmed and some other terms may be flexible.	Reveals which constraint is fixed and which levers remain open.
Candidate	Understood. Given the confirmed level, the on-call ownership, and the distributed-systems scope we discussed, I would like to explore USD 78,000 annual gross fixed cash. If that band cannot move, could we review sign-on support or a written six-month compensation review with clear criteria?	Uses exact units, role evidence, one request, and truthful alternatives without attacking the policy.
Recruiter	I can check sign-on and the review timing, but I cannot promise either today.	Keeps unknowns explicit instead of converting interest into an agreement.
Candidate	That would be helpful. May I send a short summary of the two questions so we can confirm the response and timing in writing?	Closes with ownership and a safe written record.

Avoid these reactions

+ Calling the policy unfair before understanding what it actually constrains.
+ Arguing with unsourced salary screenshots or claiming a universal global rate.
+ Explaining personal expenses as the primary business rationale.
+ Threatening to reject the offer without a real, considered boundary.
+ Accepting a verbal alternative without amount, conditions, owner, date, and written confirmation.

CHOOSE THE NEXT QUESTION FROM THE CONSTRAINT

A branching conversation prevents rehearsed monologues

Listen for what is fixed, unknown, conditional, or open. The next move should reduce a decision uncertainty, not repeat the same request in different words.

What you hear	Useful next question	Risk to avoid
What are your expectations?	Before I give a comparable number, can we confirm level, engagement model, currency, fixed/variable components, and the budgeted scope?	Anchoring against an undefined package or refusing to engage indefinitely.
We need your current salary.	Could we focus on the approved range and responsibilities for this role? I can share my expectations in the same units once those are clear.	Inventing a number, exposing documents unnecessarily, or making legal claims without context.
Base is fixed.	Which other terms are approved for discussion, and how are review timing and criteria documented?	Trading for low-value perks or treating an informal review as guaranteed pay.
We can add equity.	May I review the instrument, grant size, vesting, strike/exercise terms, expiration, and liquidity information in writing?	Valuing the headline equity amount like cash.
This is our final package.	Thank you for clarifying. May I confirm the complete written terms and response deadline so I can evaluate the package carefully?	Negotiating against yourself or accepting under artificial urgency.
We can revisit later.	What date, decision owner, performance criteria, and possible adjustment would be written into the offer or review plan?	Treating an undefined future conversation as current compensation.

A practical fallback ladder

+ Fixed cash in the same unit as the offer.
+ One-time sign-on amount with repayment conditions understood.
+ Variable target or guarantee only when formula and conditions are written.
+ Equity only after instrument and terms are available for diligence.
+ Paid leave, equipment, learning, travel, timezone overlap, on-call, or start-date changes with real personal value.
+ A written review date with decision owner, criteria, and adjustment scope - not a vague promise.
+ Role level, title, reporting line, or scope only when the work itself is accurately aligned.

TRADE DELIBERATELY

Do not offer a concession until you understand what you receive, how certain it is, and whether it changes your decision. Package flexibility is not automatically package value.

REHEARSE UNDER PRESSURE AND SCORE OBSERVABLE BEHAVIOR

Keep the same facts while changing delivery

Run the dialogue twice. The second attempt should preserve the target and rationale while improving unit precision, listening, composure, ethical boundaries, or the written close.

Dimension	0	1	2
Unit precision	Amounts/components cannot be compared.	Most units are clear; one condition remains mixed.	Currency, period, gross/net basis, component, and certainty are explicit.
Listening and clarification	Responds to an assumed objection.	Acknowledges but asks a broad or stacked question.	Reflects the constraint and asks one question that changes the next decision.
Relevant rationale	Uses need, hype, or invented market claims.	Role evidence is present but generic.	Verified scope/capability evidence directly supports the request.
Pushback composure	Argues, apologizes excessively, or discounts immediately.	Remains calm but repeats the ask without learning.	Acknowledges, clarifies, re-anchors, explores, and pauses.
Ethical boundary	Bluff, false deadline/offer, or concealed uncertainty.	No fabrication, but facts and assumptions are mixed.	Facts, unknowns, boundaries, and confidentiality are explicit.
Written close	No agreed summary or accidental acceptance.	Summary exists but owner/date/open item is missing.	Agreed facts, open items, owners, timing, and non-acceptance are clear.

Pressure rounds

Round	Recruiter move	Learner objective
A	Expectation requested before range or package details.	Clarify comparable units and role boundary, then provide a reasoned target if needed.
B	Location-based fixed-cash band is cited.	Clarify the constrained component and re-anchor once in role evidence.
C	Base is fixed but another lever is offered vaguely.	Ask for exact terms and compare certainty/value before trading.
D	A quick verbal answer is requested.	Ask for the complete written offer and a clear review deadline.
Replay	Repeat the learner's weakest turn verbatim.	Change one behavior only and record why the response became safer or clearer.

SCORE REASON

Write one quoted sentence or timestamp beside every point. Confidence and politeness matter, but the rubric scores decisions the learner can repeat and improve.

CLOSE WITHOUT CREATING A FALSE AGREEMENT

Confirm facts, unknowns, owners, and dates

A short written summary reduces unit confusion and gives both sides a clean record. It should not add new demands, imply acceptance, or turn a respectful conversation into an adversarial memo.

Fictional follow-up structure

Section	Example content
Appreciation	Thank you for discussing the role and package today. I remain interested in the distributed-systems scope and confirmed level.
Confirmed facts	Current fixed-cash offer: USD 72,000 annual gross through the stated EOR; other terms remain subject to the written offer.
Open requests	Please check whether sign-on support or a six-month compensation review can be included, with amount/criteria, owner, and timing.
Documents/questions	Please share the complete offer and applicable bonus, equity, benefits, on-call, notice, and review terms when available.
Timing	You expect to respond by Thursday; I will review the complete written terms and reply by the mutually confirmed deadline.
Boundary	This note records the discussion and is not acceptance of terms.

Final rehearsal checklist

- [ ] The engagement model and every amount use comparable currency, period, basis, component, and certainty labels.
- [ ] The target and fallback ladder reflect the learner's real priorities and verified role evidence.
- [ ] The learner asks one clarifying question before responding to location, range, current-salary, equity, or deadline pressure.
- [ ] No fabricated offer, benchmark, salary, deadline, authority, or willingness to walk away appears.
- [ ] Every alternative is evaluated for terms, conditions, certainty, and actual decision value.
- [ ] The close records confirmed facts, unknowns, owners, dates, and non-acceptance where appropriate.
- [ ] Legal, tax, currency, classification, and equity uncertainties are marked for qualified diligence rather than guessed.

STRONG SIGNAL

Keep

Calm pace, exact units, relevant evidence, one request, one question, honest uncertainty, and a written record.

RISK

Remove

Bluffing, excessive justification, argument about geography, unsourced benchmarks, premature concessions, and verbal-only assumptions.

NEXT ACTION

Complete the anchor card, rehearse the location-based pushback twice, score both attempts with quoted evidence, and send only a truthful written summary after a real conversation.